of talks held with them continued to assure them that the MSP regime would remain unaffected.[9]

The Supreme Court intervened, offering to set up a neutral panel of experts, bringing in a stay order on the laws until the panel concluded its report.[10] In all disregard for the law of the land, the protesting groups refused to budge from the borders and protesting sites. Images of them organizing movie nights and exquisite pizza parties at the protesting sites began to do the media rounds, leaving many wondering about their motives and source of funds.[11] Neither were they willing to have a dialogue with the government, nor were they respectful of the Supreme Court's judgement, which is the highest law of the land. In fact, about 10 months later, in October 2021, the Supreme Court once again reprimanded the protestors, 'We have stayed the farm laws. There is nothing to be implemented. What are the farmers protesting about? No one other than the court can decide the validity of the farm laws. When that is so, and when farmers are in court challenging the laws, why protest on the street?'[12]

In Indian politics over the years, the poor farmer is often used as a symbol of vote-bank appeasement. Images of farmers out in the cold, sleeping in their tractors, created a hot political atmosphere for the Opposition to take strikes at the Modi government. The BJP ally in Punjab, the Shiromani Akali Dal, walked out of the NDA as soon as the bills were passed in Parliament. After all, if they hadn't, they'd have to risk their core vote-bank, considering the fact that most protestors were from Punjab. The Congress and other regional parties in the Opposition labelled the laws as anti-farmer and demanded that the government repeal them immediately.[13] Interestingly, many of these parties had promised in their manifestos that if voted to power, they'd bring in similar reforms in the agro-sector. To offer context, it is important to note that agriculture policy is a state subject and agriculture is in the state list under the Constitution. Entry 33 of the Concurrent List provides the states powers to control production, supply and distribution of products of any industry, including agriculture. This means that each state would have the power to stop these laws from being implemented in their respective states if they wished to. Also noteworthy is that several states already had many of these mechanisms introduced in the Centre's new laws in place for years. For instance, Maharashtra, since 2000, under the Congress and NCP regime, had been issuing licences to